



Security Watch

Windows SETABORTPROC Arbitrary Code Execution

The Problem

A vulnerability has been discovered in Windows, which can be exploited to compromise a vulnerable system. The vulnerability is caused due to an error in the handling of Windows Metafile files (files with the .wmf extension) containing specially-crafted SETABORTPROC "Escape" records.

The vulnerability, rated "extremely critical," can also be exploited automatically when a user visits a malicious Web site using Internet Explorer. It has been confirmed on a fully-patched system running Microsoft Windows XP SP2, Windows 2000, Windows XP SP1 and Microsoft Windows Server 2003 SP0 / SP1 are also affected.

The Damages

The "Escape" records mentioned above allow arbitrary user-defined functions to be executed when the rendering of a WMF file fails. This can be exploited to execute arbitrary code by tricking a user into opening a malicious ".wmf" file in Windows Picture and Fax Viewer, or previewing a malicious .wmf file in Windows Explorer (opening a folder containing a malicious image file).

The Solution

Apply the appropriate patches. For Windows 2000 with SP4, visit <http://snipurl.com/digitsec1>. For Windows XP Professional with SP1 or SP2, visit <http://snipurl.com/ld40>.

WE'VE GOT YOUR NUMBER

India's Employee Database

Nasscom (National Association of Software and Service Companies) recently announced the launch of the world's first IT professional manpower database.

What's this database, you ask? Well, the database contains your name, address, phone number, current employer, and more, along with details of your past employment, and, if applicable, problems with your previous employer.

Using this database, employers can find out whether or not you have any legal suits against you for criminal behaviour, as well as recommendations, felicitations, past history, etc.

A first-of-its-kind for IT professionals across the globe, the National Skills Registry (www.nationalskillsregistry.com) is the first step towards security and reliability. The BPO industry, perhaps more than any other sector, needs this sort of protection: early in 2005, India was rocked by a \$4,00,000 (Rs 1.8 crore) online theft from a bank outsourcing to India.

Supposedly, this happened because someone

sold personal credit card information and used that to withdraw and transfer the two crores of rupees.

With over 1 million people working for the BPO industry, and 3 million more indirectly employed by it, it's a huge decision when you hire someone. The database will also help the police run background checks when complaints are made against employees. BPO firms can register with the database service and even choose to leave negative comments about—pay attention here—an employee's behaviour, mood, and so on!

The FAQ lists the benefits to hiring companies (subscribers to the database). These include the fact that the "menace of bloated resumes will be eliminated," which, we think, is a good thing. The risk of hiring an employee on the basis of forged documents will be minimised. Also, the benefit of background checks done by any of the NASSCOM member companies will be available to all other members—this will save the cost and time typically involved in a background check. Finally—and we like this point—the FAQ says that with this database in place, Indian Industry can "confidently claim higher standards of recruitment practices and retain its competitive advantage."

How will such a database actually benefit

HOT

SATA And SATA II

If you're getting a new hard drive, you'll probably opt for SATA. The list of advantages over IDE is long, including higher data bandwidth, longer cables, hot-swapping, and much more. SATA II can be twice as fast.



EIDE (PATA) Drives

EIDE is gradually being phased out—they've been around too long. Intel's plan, for example, is not to support IDE drives after 2007. This is good news for compulsive upgraders!



NOT

you? We learn from the FAQ at nationalskillsregistry.com that "benefit to the IT and ITes industry is your benefit." It seems that foreign clients, government and public bodies, are increasingly insisting on background checks of individuals before recruitment. And thus, if you're registered and certified as crime-free and squeaky-clean, you'll be able to "showcase" yourself to foreign clients.

Then there's the issue of faking resumes; with a database of this kind in place, you benefit because the fakers won't stand a chance. (Unless you're a faker yourself, in which case you stand to suffer!)

There's also the issue of the time taken for background checks. "Your employer will save time on



One Silly Question

"Whom do you blame when your computer crashes?"



"My technician"
Sharmili Borkar, Goa



"The Government?"
Gagan Saini, Punjab



"My brother, coz he ruins most things!!"
Delma Sarkar, Durgapur



"You, of course!"
Chintan Makwana, Mumbai



"Bill Gates, I think!"
Saaquib Sawant, Maharashtra